the Fujiwara chancellor to control them.*

He was able to do this for only a few months, dying unexpectedly before his fortieth birthday. But the sharp turn he had given to Japan's power structure survived. Shirakawa followed in his father's footsteps, refusing to obey his chancellor and favoring Minamoto and Taira courtiers over the Fujiwara. And like his father, he abdicated at the height of his power, handing over the throne at age thirty-three and taking monastic vows. But he continued to rule actively from his monastery, exercising as much control over his young successors—first his son Horikawa and then his grandson Toba—as the Fujiwara regents had once done. It was said by his subjects that there were only three things the retired emperor could not control: the floods of the wild Kamo river, the troublesome warrior monks who lived on Mount Hiei, and the throw of the dice.[4]

This was the beginning of a two-hundred-year tradition of Cloistered Emperors, during which emperors abdicated at the height of their powers, leaving the throne to child heirs, and then went on ruling from behind the scenes. Everyone knew who was in charge: "After Shirakawa's abdication," says the *Gukansho*, "the state was governed for a long time by Retired Emperors."[5]




*9.1 Japan under the Cloistered Emperors*

It was not an entirely impractical system. The Cloistered Emperor regime